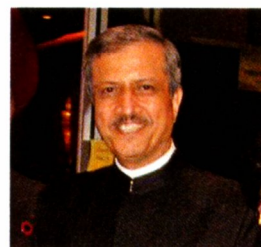




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(CLOCKWISE FROM LEFT)
THE TAJ MAHAL HOTEL
DURING 26/11; ATTRI;
HEADLEY; RANA

DELHI | Passport To Terror

Reputations in Chicago are going down, particularly those that belong to one of India's most sensitive diplomatic outposts. The granting of visas to alleged Lashkar-e-Toiba operatives David Coleman Headley and Tahawwur Hussain Rana by the Indian consulate in the Windy City has come as a major embarrassment. At the core of the lapse is the role played by India's Consul General Ashok Attri for using his discretionary powers to grant long-term visas to Rana and his wife Samraz without prior verification checks. Home Ministry sources say that the consulate did not even verify Rana's address—even though he is of Pakistani origin—which turned out to be fake. He received a one-year multiple-entry visa while Samraz got a five-year visa. Headley was given a five-year multiple-entry visa. While visas for those of Indian origin and other nationalities take several days to process, Rana and his wife's were fast-tracked. The MEA, which had earlier defended Attri, is now on the defensive. Foreign Secretary Nirupama Rao has asked Attri to be present in Washington with an explanation. An inquiry is also underway to probe if agents connived with consulate officials to facilitate Headley and Rana's visas. *by Saurabh Shukla*

5

is the number of years Headley's visa, issued by the Indian consulate in Chicago, was valid for.